his own name was on the list. The Angel replied in the negative. Disappointed but stil cheerful, Abou said, “Write my name down as one that loves his fel owmen”. The angel wrote, and vanished. The next night, it came again with a great wakening light, and showed the names of those whom the love of God had blessed. And Abou’s name was the first on the list.

I sat for a long time with my mother, but could not speak. She blessed me in a choked voice when I took leave of her to return to Thumba. She knew that she was not to leave the house of her husband, of which she was the custodian, and I was not to live with her there. Both of us had to live out our own destinies. Was I too stubborn or was I excessively preoccupied with the SLV? Should I not have forgotten for a while my own affairs in order to listen to her? I regretful y realised this only when she passed away soon afterwards.

The SLV-3 Apogee rocket, developed as a common upper stage with Diamont, scheduled to be flight tested in France was mired in a series of knotty problems. I had to rush to France to sort them out. Before I could depart, late in the afternoon, I was informed that my mother had passed away. I took the first available bus to Nagarcoil. From there,